Sunrise on the Reaping Director Keeps Secrets About Haymitch and Maysilee

From: /Film Mined: 2026-10-27 5 min read

The Hunger Games: Sunrise on the Reaping arrives in theaters on November 20, 2026, bringing Suzanne Collins's 2025 book to the big screen. The story follows Haymitch Abernathy, played by Joseph Zada, and his fellow District 12 **tribute** Maysilee Donner, played by McKenna Grace.

Director Francis Lawrence, who has directed every Hunger Games movie except the first, recently talked about the bond between the two characters. He said he spent a lot of time with Zada and Grace during **rehearsals** in Spain, talking constantly about Haymitch and Maysilee. Lawrence said the three of them kept some secrets about the relationship to help shape how the characters act toward each other.

One detail fascinates Lawrence: even though Haymitch and Maysilee have known each other their entire lives, she slams the door in his face when she sees him. Lawrence said there may be other parts of their story that Collins has not written about, and the actors use their private ideas to understand why the two clash and why they bond.

Fans of the earlier books may already know something about this pair. In Catching Fire, published in 2009, Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark watch footage of the 50th Games, where Haymitch and Maysilee formed an **alliance** against double the usual number of **tributes**. Maysilee also connects to Katniss: Peeta points out that Katniss's **mockingjay** pin came from the Donner family, and Maysilee's twin sister Merrilee is the mother of Katniss's friend Madge.

This time, there are four District 12 **tributes** instead of two, and Haymitch first tries to avoid teaming up with anyone. The youngest is Louella McCoy, whom Haymitch has protected since they were playground sweethearts. Lawrence also mapped out fun links between Louella and Katniss: both are young, dark-haired, braid-wearing **heroines**, and Haymitch calls both of them sweetheart.

Word Treasure

tribute -- A tribute is a person chosen to take part in the Games.

rehearsals -- Rehearsals are practice sessions where actors work through their scenes before filming.

alliance -- An alliance is when people team up and help each other.

mockingjay -- A mockingjay is a bird, and in this story a pin shaped like one links Maysilee's family to Katniss.

heroines -- Heroines are girls or women who are the brave main characters of a story.

Background you need

The Hunger Games began as a series of books, and the films bring those stories to the screen with actors playing the book characters.

A director guides the actors, helping them understand how their characters feel about each other and why they act the way they do.

In rehearsals, actors practise scenes and talk through their characters before filming starts, so their performances feel real.

This film tells an earlier part of the story, showing how two characters who later matter to Katniss first knew each other.

Break it down

LEAD: Director Francis Lawrence kept private ideas about Haymitch and Maysilee's bond with stars Joseph Zada and McKenna Grace ahead of the November 20, 2026 film.

KEY EVENT: Lawrence talked about building the pair's bond during rehearsals in Spain.

+- WHO: Haymitch Abernathy (Joseph Zada) and Maysilee Donner (McKenna Grace), District 12 tributes.

+- DETAIL: Maysilee slams the door in Haymitch's face, though they have known each other all their lives.

+- UNCERTAINTY: There may be parts of their story that Collins has not written about.

EVIDENCE: In Catching Fire (2009), Katniss and Peeta watch footage of the 50th Games alliance, and Peeta notes the mockingjay pin came from the Donner family.

LINK: Louella McCoy, the youngest of four District 12 tributes, shares links with Katniss, and Haymitch calls both of them sweetheart.

Why it matters

It shows how actors and directors build believable friendships on screen, and how a new film can deepen a story fans already know.

Test what you remember

1. **When does The Hunger Games: Sunrise on the Reaping arrive in theaters?**
   - (A) November 20, 2026
   - (B) November 20, 2025
   - (C) December 20, 2026
   - (D) October 20, 2026
2. **Who plays Maysilee Donner?**
   - (A) Joseph Zada
   - (B) McKenna Grace
   - (C) Suzanne Collins
   - (D) Francis Lawrence
3. **What did Lawrence, Zada and Grace keep secret?**
   - (A) The film's release date
   - (B) Louella McCoy's name
   - (C) The ending of the book
   - (D) Their private ideas about Haymitch and Maysilee's relationship
4. **In the footage from Catching Fire, what did Haymitch and Maysilee do in the 50th Games?**
   - (A) They formed an alliance against double the usual number of tributes
   - (B) They left District 12
   - (C) They directed the Games
   - (D) They refused to take part
5. **How is Maysilee connected to Katniss's mockingjay pin?**
   - (A) She made the pin for Katniss
   - (B) The pin belonged to Haymitch
   - (C) She bought the pin in District 12
   - (D) Katniss's pin came from the Donner family
6. **Who is the youngest of the four District 12 tributes this time?**
   - (A) Maysilee Donner
   - (B) Louella McCoy
   - (C) Merrilee
   - (D) Katniss Everdeen

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Director Francis Lawrence: He finds the pair's clash and bond fascinating and uses private ideas shared with the actors to shape how they act toward each other.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):